



“Vaccination among adolescents should grow after Covid-19. As HPVs can prevent cervical cancer, several other vaccines can prevent... many other deadly diseases. This can be a good investment opportunity for pharma companies”

ADAR POONAWALLA
CEO, SERUM
INSTITUTE OF INDIA



“We are committed to ensuring our expansive vaccine portfolio offers the best protection against several vaccine-preventable diseases by making numerous enhancements to our products”

DR PARAG SHETH
REGIONAL MEDICAL
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older children are not given adequate attention. Barring TT, there is no data on the coverage of the vaccines given to adolescents in India,” the study says.

“Several VPDs are highly prevalent in India, including influenza, typhoid fever, rotavirus, diphtheria, tetanus, pertussis, Japanese encephalitis and more, which affect all age groups. India has the largest adolescent population in the world... and increased uptake of large-scale immunisation coverage, including across adolescents, is essential to tackle the burden of prevailing VPDs,” says Sheth.

The disease burden among adolescents in India is increasing day by day. Different studies have shown Hepatitis A virus sero-prevalence—the level of a pathogen in a population—to be around 38-92 per cent in different age groups, says the health ministry. “The Covid-19 vaccination for adolescents should be a guiding light for parents to get their children vaccinated for [other] diseases as well,” says Dr Dinesh Kapil, Senior Consultant-Paediatrics, Red Cross Hospital, Delhi.

According to the National Centre for Disease Control (NCDC), despite the heavier burden of diseases, vaccines recommended for adults are not widely used in India. There are several reasons for that, including limited perception and doubts about the efficacy and safety of vaccines for adults. Also, adult immunisation is selective and healthy adults are harder to reach through the public health system and hence

the vaccination of this age group becomes difficult, the NCDC notes.

“The adolescent and adult immunisation recommendations introduced by the Association of Physicians of India outlined evidence-based information on vaccines. Recognising the shift in epidemiological diseases affecting the adolescent age group, many nations [have] established adolescent-specific immunisation guidelines. Similar recommendations for India can empower practitioners to recommend appropriate vaccines to adolescents,” says Sheth.

PUBLIC HEALTH experts believe the initiation of Covid-19 vaccination among adolescents in India may prove to be a game-changer for populations aged above five. “The Covid-19 pandemic is a reminder of the need for life-course immunisation, which is also particularly relevant in the context of the [WHO’s] Immunization Agenda 2030 and GAVI 5.0,” says Dr Naveen Thacker, President-elect, International Pediatric Association, and former civil society organisation representative to GAVI, the Vaccine Alliance.

Dr Devlina Chakravarty, MD, Artemis Hospitals, believes that the logistics, supply chain and outreach to various far-flung areas will improve with time and more adolescents will be vaccinated against Covid-19. The same infrastructure could then be used for adolescent vaccinations, she says.

Experts believe that the government might want to use this opportunity to draft a new policy on adolescent vaccination. “Extrapolating the success of the initial vaccination drive of children less than 18 years of age, it can be anticipated that the same level of vaccination enthusiasm is likely to be there for the Covid-19 vaccination drive of adolescents as well,” says Dr Dipu T.S., Associate Professor, Division of Infectious Disease, Amrita Hospital, Kochi. And, if the population is amenable to vaccination as a strategy to reduce communicable diseases, then the scope of the inoculation programme can be expanded. That way, he says, India can ensure that adolescents, the future of the country, are protected. **BT**

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